



Writing an Action Plan

To turn your business strategy into reality, you will need to create an action plan. This sets out the specific steps that have to be taken to ensure that your business thrives.

Understanding the basics

Your action plan should be designed to follow through on your business strategy (see pp.36–37). Your strategy outlines the overall direction of your business and the major decisions you need to take—such as identifying who your customers will be and what your business will look like in five years' time. However, your action plan should provide precise details about your goals and the actions needed to achieve them in the day-to-day running of your business.

When writing your action plan, involve your colleagues so you can create and share new ideas. Inviting others to contribute also means that you are more likely to earn their commitment to making your venture a success.

Getting started

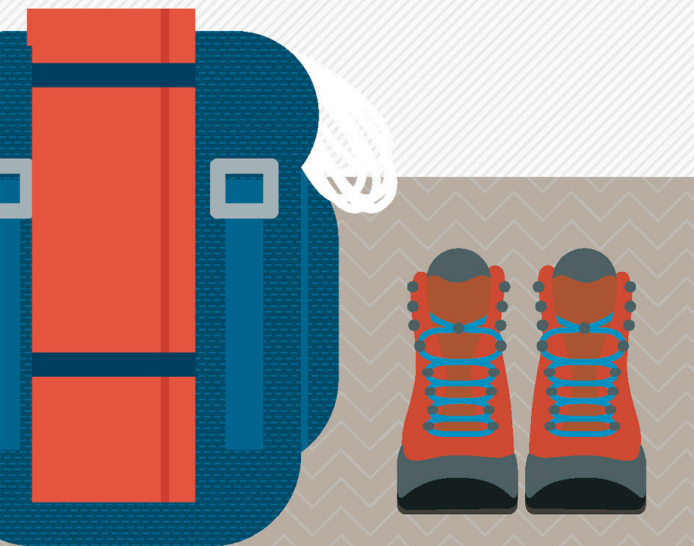
Start by thinking about the different aspects of your company, such as marketing, production, and finance. Depending on how complex your business is, you may want to write a plan for

each sphere. Make sure that there are no conflicting deadlines in your plan and that the various aspects of your business will not have to compete for the same resources. If your business is small, you may be able to cover all of your activities in a single plan.

To measure the success of your action plan, specify deadlines by which key tasks have to be completed, and meet regularly with your staff to discuss any changes that need to be made. Be prepared to update your plan as necessary.

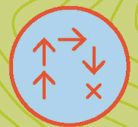
Making a plan

In this example, a mountain tour guide company wants to tell potential customers about its new winter routes, so it develops an action plan based on marketing. More complex steps in the plan, such as the social media campaign, will benefit from having their own, more detailed action plans.



THE GOAL

To increase awareness and sales of the tour guide company's new winter mountain routes



KEY STEPS TO TAKE

Email existing customers about the new winter routes, offering discounts

Arrange advertising on hiking and mountaineering websites

Run a social media campaign that publicizes exciting features of the new route